behavior of far-flung officials. One of those spies, failing to provide an update on the doings of a provincial governor, was publicly executed and hung up on the city gate of his target.[14]

In the disorderly years since Iltumish, explains Balban's biographer Ziauddin Barani, the people of Delhi had become "vacillating, disobedient, self-willed." Balban's unyielding hand on Delhi's reins restored peace: "The dignity and authority of government were restored," Barani writes. "Fear of the governing power, which is the basis of all good government . . . had departed from the hearts of all men, and the country had fallen into a wretched condition. But from the very commencement of the reign of Balban the people became tractable, obedient, and submissive." The Turkish slave, risen to the sultanate, had reduced his people to the state he had once endured: obedient and submissive, slaves.[15]